# **Aria Whalen** (she/her)

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## Summary

Detail-oriented Biologist and Conservationist with more than 4 years of experience in ecological data collection, environmental education, data manipulation, statistical analysis, local plant and animal identification, chainsaw use, herbicide application, and prescribed burning. Proven experience with ArcGIS and Rstudio. Experienced in working within teams to achieve research objectives. Committed to improving the health of our shared natural environment while promoting inclusive environmental awareness and accessible education to people of all ages and backgrounds.

## Education

**St. Olaf College**, Northfield, MN — Graduation Date: May 2026

**Bachelor of Arts, Major in Biology** | GPA: 3.89

• *Concentrations in Environmental Studies, Statistics & Data Science*

## Work and Research Experiences

**Natural Lands Assistant** — *June 2026 - December 2026*

St. Olaf College Natural Lands – Northfield, MN

- Manages a team of student employees and volunteers to engage effectively in restoration and outreach
- Experience with writing prescribed burn plans and participating in the burn crew
- Practice in mixing and application of herbicides
- Skilled at efficient and accurate seed collection on a wide variety of native plants
- Participates in ongoing research project data collection and statistical analysis
- Independently executes high quality website management and mapping
- Trained in effective usage of trail mowers, tractors, UTVs, chainsaws, brushsaws, and a variety of hand tools
- Emphasis on the importance of high quality outreach and education

**Greenvale Lone Oak Nature Area Restoration Project** — *Fall 2025*

Biology Department, St. Olaf College

- Identified over 100 native species of flora and fauna in the area, as well as several non-native species populations
- Worked with multiple local professionals to design a comprehensive, multi-year restoration plan in the area that includes and engages local elementary school students in outdoor education and restoration
- Collaborated with college staff to implement an Academic Civic Engagement project through a key St. Olaf Environmental Studies class to incorporate students at St. Olaf into leading the project in future years

**Naturalist** — *Summer 2025*

Harbor WildWatch – Gig Harbor, WA

- Created dynamic and engaging exhibit materials for public education
- Collected biodiversity data at various beaches to inform local scientists on environmental health
- Provided exceptional service by engaging guests in conversations about marine ecosystems and conservation
- Collaborated with naturalists, volunteers, and education staff to plan and deliver hands-on educational programs
- Worked successfully in a dynamic team environment, coordinating with nonprofit staff, and community partners to support outreach and conservation efforts
- Designed high quality marketing materials and signage for outreach and education efforts
- Conducted maintenance/husbandry duties for saltwater aquariums, ensuring health of fish and invertebrates

**Research Fellowship** — *September 2025 - May 2026*

Center for Interdisciplinary Research - St. Olaf College, Northfield, MN

- Utilized data manipulation skills to create a high quality dataset on Women's Club creation in the United States from 1865 to 1925.
- Sourced multiple datasets from IPUMS National Historical Geographic Information System database and joined them to our previous data to create our predictive model
- Utilized hurdle models to create an accurate statistical analysis of our dataset
- Worked collaboratively with students and professionals to clearly communicate findings on a weekly basis
- Presented research at the Spring 2026 SDSS conference through lightning talks and poster sessions

**Marine Ecology Research Project** *January 2025*

Biology Department, St. Olaf College Study Abroad; *Supervisor - Dr. Steve Freedberg*

- Designed and conducted study on distribution and microorganism presence of marine brown algae in Jamaica
- Collected field data on proportion of brown algae relative to other local algaes using quadrats
- Analyzed algae water samples under dissecting microscope to measure microorganisms counts
- Interpreted and visualized data using R studio
- Results contributed to understanding of distribution and algae-microbe interactions in coastal ecosystems

**Animal Behavior Research Project** Fall *2024*

Biology Department, St. Olaf College; *Supervisor - Dr. Norman Lee*

- Refined and conducted study on reproduction based sensory changes in acoustic parasitoid fly with Lee Lab
- Conceptualized and submitted project proposal to lab head
- Collected behavioral data from reproductive and non-reproductive flies in response to sound
- Interpreted and visualized data using DeepLabCut and R studio

**R-Studio "R-Star" Course Assistant** *September 2024 – May 2026*

Biology Department – St. Olaf College, Northfield, MN

- Hosted bi-weekly clinics to assist biology students with coding needs in R Studio
- Met with students 1 on 1 as requested for specific R Studio learning needs
- Attended lab and class sessions to provide exceptional assistance to professors and students in R Studio
- Created high quality educational materials for learning R Studio in a classroom lesson plans
- Took over 100 pages of notes on using RStudio, which was shared accessibly for problem solving

**Student Farmer** *February 2024 – May 2025, Fall 2025*

Biology Department – St. Olaf College, Northfield, MN

- Worked with a team to successfully plant, care for, and harvest student-run 1.5 acre farm on campus
- Researched and implemented sustainable farming methods (intercropping, cover cropping, natural pest repellant)
- Managed communications, harvests, and sales of produce to local vendor

**Ceramics Studio Technician**, *January 2024 - May 2026*

Art Department - St. Olaf College, Northfield, MN

- Upheld daily studio needs including mixing of clay, glazes & slips and wet washing surfaces
- Managed safe loading and operation of electric bisque kilns and cone 10 reduction gas kilns
- Assisted students with education on throwing, handbuilding, glazing, and studio tool use

**Kitchen Assistant** *September 2022 - February 2024*

Bon Appetit - St. Olaf College, Northfield, MN

- Prepped vegetables in a timely manner for upcoming meals
- Cooked high quality meals in an efficient manner to serve hundreds of students within a short time period
- Ensured stations were fully stocked at all times for a smooth meal service

**Head Cook** *July 2021 - August 2022, Summer 2023*

Holden Village, WA

- Collaborated with fellow head cooks to plan and organize meals
- Skillfully educated volunteers of varying skill levels on kitchen procedures and quality recipe execution
- Oversaw volunteers in timely food preparation and sanitation, serving up to 350 individuals daily

## Relevant Skills, Trainings, and Classes

- **Software:** RStudio, ArcGIS Pro & Online, WordPress, Microsoft Excel & Word, Google Sheets & Docs, Canva
- **Certifications and hardskills:** Minnesota non-commercial herbicide Categories A, E and J, Chainsaw SAWW 1 & 2, Private land Prescribed Fire, Local Flora + Fauna Identification
- **Coursework in:** Statistics for Science, Statistics 2, Advance Statistical Modeling, Data Science 1, Data Science 2, Spatial Data Analysis, Principles of Data Visualization, Remote Sensing & GIS, Biodiversity Foundations, Principles of Ecology, Field Ecology, Marine Ecology, Animal Behavior, Environmental Studies I + II, Intro Chemistry I + II